Standby generator maintenance schedule

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For home and light-commercial standby generators that sit ready and run during outages.
Most of the work is yearly, but long outages pile on run hours fast, so the oil change can come due in the middle of one.

Typical intervals from manufacturer manuals and published service schedules. Your machine's manual comes first.

Every exercise run (weekly to monthly)

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Let the automatic exercise run	Weekly, every 2 weeks or monthly	Set in the controller; runs about 5 to 20 minutes depending on the model	
Walk around it while it runs	Each exercise	Leaks, debris against the enclosure, blocked exhaust, warning lights	

By run hours

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
First oil change (break-in)	After the first 20 to 25 hours	New units only	
Engine oil and filter	Every 100 to 200 run hours	Change it mid-outage if you hit the hours; use the low end in very hot or cold weather	

Yearly

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Engine oil and filter (if hours didn't trigger it)	Every 1 to 2 years	At least every 2 years no matter the hours	
Battery condition and charge	Yearly		
Air filter	Inspect yearly	Replace per your manual	
Fuel system leak check	Yearly	Gas or LP connections	
Check for water getting in and corrosion	Yearly	Treat any corrosion you find	
Spark plugs	Per manual	Often several hundred hours; natural gas and LP plugs last longer	
Professional service visit	Yearly	Recommended by the major makers	

Required by code? Generators that are legally required emergency power (like in health care or life-safety systems) fall under NFPA 110, which adds weekly inspections, monthly 30-minute load runs, monthly transfer switch tests and written logs. A typical optional standby unit at a home or small shop usually just follows the manufacturer's schedule. Code items apply where your city, state or insurer has adopted them. Requirements vary by jurisdiction, so check local code.

Service log: standby generator

Machine / unit: _____ Make & model: _____

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DATE	RUN HOURS	WORK DONE	PARTS USED	INITIALS

Free printable from fleetoptima.org/maintenance-schedules